up from sites in the region.[1] Agricultural settlements had for long existed here, in what have been described as the 'toothpaste squeezes' of rivers and tributaries.[2] These are found in a fairly large stretch, in the area of the Amu Darya river in the north, and in the southern mountains and foothills. The fourth millennium BCE saw the appearance of pottery in an extensive series of mounds at Mundigak near Kandahar, sharing clear parallels with ceramics from sites in Baluchistan. Those, in turn, occasionally had motifs that appear to be of Iranian inspiration.[3] All this is perfectly logical since an important route to Baluchistan from Iran passed through Kandahar. The ceramic parallels also show that, to begin with, Afghanistan's relationship with Baluchistan was far more crucial while with the more distant regions to the west, the cultural interaction was limited.[4] Later, in the third millennium BCE, the material culture of this area shows parallels with that seen in Iranian sites of the same timespan. Shahr-i Sokhta in Iran manufactured alabaster vessels which reached Mundigak.[5] As for northern Afghanistan, in the third millennium BCE a Bronze Age commercial outpost, exclusively marked by antiquities and artefacts of Harappan tradition, was flourishing at Shortughai near the Kokcha river.[6] Shortughai perhaps represents the earliest Indian diaspora community settled far from its land of origin while maintaining strong links with it. Harappan settlers came here for its rich resources, ranging from metal ores to the deep blue lapis lazuli stone of Badakshan. Lapis was fashioned into beads worn in Harappan settlements stretching from Punjab to Gujarat.

With the advent of the early historical period the political imprint of rulers with an appetite for vast tracts of territory swims into view, these being conquerors who brought Afghanistan within the ambit of their empires. In the sixth century BCE, when the Achaemenids from Iran made central-south Afghanistan a province of their realm, Kandahar became their main bastion. From that point in time, very likely, the Aramaic language, steeped in local Iranian terms, came to be used in the administration here.